1 Evidence Lab

Footprints and mystery powder · Evidence envelope: **CLUE 1**

11 min: 1 explain / 8 do / 2 hand over and reset | Medium energy | Arrive 1:05

> **SAY**
> "Every footprint tells a story. Measure twice. Then let's find out what that powder is."

Run it

1. Count off 1 to 5 (jobs at right). Rulers 1 and 2 measure the footprint under the sheet protector in cm and agree on **one** number.
2. Reveal the shoe-size chart. 26 cm = size 9. The chart reader writes it in the case file.
3. Powder test: the chemist puts a pinch of each labeled powder on the tray, one pipette of vinegar each. Which fizzes? (Baking soda.)
4. The evidence tech tests the EVIDENCE powder. It fizzes. "So it's baking soda. Interesting. Remember that at Station 2."
5. At the bell: hand over the sealed **CLUE 1** envelope for this squad. Wipe the tray. Refill powder cups.

Fixes

- Measurements disagree: measure heel to toe together, once.
- Fast squad: lift a fingerprint off a cup with pencil graphite and tape.
- Kid won't touch powder: swap jobs with a ruler.

Five detectives, five jobs

Count off 1 to 5 as they arrive. New count at every station, so the jobs shuffle.

1. **Ruler.** Measures the footprint heel to toe, calls out the number.
2. **Second ruler.** Measures it again. Different numbers? Both measure once more, together.
3. **Chart reader.** Finds the number on the Bureau chart, announces the size, writes it in the case file.
4. **Chemist.** A pinch of each known powder on the tray, one pipette of vinegar on each. Which fizzed?
5. **Evidence tech.** Tests the EVIDENCE powder, announces the result, writes it in the case file.

Say "candy" until Video 1 has played. Say "squishies" after.

Every squad arrives knowing what the whole room knows. Don't get ahead of the story.

Bin

- Footprint sheet + clear sheet protector
- 5 rulers, pencils
- Shoe-size chart
- 3 labeled powder cups + EVIDENCE cup (baking soda)
- Vinegar cup, 4 pipettes, rimmed tray
- Paper towels, wipes
- 4 CLUE 1 envelopes (one per squad)
- Backup Wanted sketch sheets

2 Ghostbuster Lab

Fizz open the evidence · Evidence envelope: **CLUE 2**

11 min | High energy | Arrive 1:05



> **SAY**
> "These ghosts are holding evidence hostage. The only thing they can't survive is vinegar. One syringe each. Bust them."

Run it

1. Count off 1 to 5. Five ghosts in the bin, one per detective. Each gets a syringe of green vinegar.
2. Bust the ghost until it fizzes apart and the word slip appears. Sleeves up.
3. Each detective lays their own word in the line. Whoever got SEEN reads the sentence aloud: **"SEEN IN HALL AT 2:15."** Whoever got 2:15 writes it in the case file.
4. At the bell: hand over the **CLUE 2** envelope (same sentence, sealed, for the file). Scoop out the residue, set five fresh ghosts.

Fixes

- Ghost won't break: more vinegar, poke it with the syringe tip.
- Kid doesn't want to touch it: they're the reader who assembles the words.
- Words out of order: "Read it like a sentence. Where does SEEN go?"

Five detectives, five jobs

Count off 1 to 5 as they arrive. New count at every station, so the jobs shuffle.

1. **Everyone:** one ghost, one syringe. Bust it until your word slip appears.
2. **Everyone:** lay your word in the line on the table and move it until the sentence reads right.
3. **Whoever got SEEN** reads the sentence aloud.
4. **Whoever got 2:15** writes it in the case file.
5. **Whoever got HALL** scoops the fizz into the bin at the bell.

Mess control

Tablecloth under the bin. Fizz stays in the bin. The residue is harmless but keep sleeves up and wipes within reach.

Bin

- 25 baking-soda ghosts, in muffin tins
- Pitcher of green vinegar
- 6 syringes (one spare)
- Big under-bed bin as the lab tray
- Tablecloth, paper towels, wipes
- 4 CLUE 2 envelopes
- Backup sketch sheets

3 The Cipher Room

Ransom note and invisible ink · Evidence envelope: **CLUE 3**



11 min | Calm station | Arrive 1:10

SAY

"The thief left a note and thinks we can't read it. Prove them wrong. Then check the paper again. Thieves always leave something behind."

Run it

1. Count off 1 to 5. Hand the squad a ransom note and the Pigpen key. Five words, one per detective; letters go on the lines under the shapes. About 3 minutes.
2. Once 1 has read the note aloud: "Now sweep the blacklight across the whole page." (2 holds the light.)
3. The highlighter P.S. appears: **"SNAGGED MY BLUE SWEATER ON THE SHELF. WORTH IT."** 3 reads it aloud, 4 writes it in the case file.
4. Each detective writes a one-line secret message in Pigpen on a take-home card (mini key on the back) for someone at home to crack.
5. At the bell: hand over the **CLUE 3** envelope. Collect the key; the used note stays with you.

Hints and fixes

- Two free hints per squad. Make them ask.
- Stuck: give them the first word.
- Fast: they write a second message for the next squad to solve.
- Stuck on a dot: "A dot means the second trip through the grid."

Five detectives, five jobs

Count off 1 to 5 as they arrive. New count at every station, so the jobs shuffle.

1. **Everyone:** one word each, five words for five detectives. Write each letter on the line under its shape.
2. **1** reads the whole note aloud once every word is done.
3. **2** holds the blacklight and sweeps the page.
4. **3** reads the P.S. aloud.
5. **4** writes it in the case file. **5** keeps the key and helps anyone stuck on a dot.

Answer

Every note says the same thing: **YOU WILL NEVER FIND IT**. Five words, 18 letters.

Bin

- 4 ransom notes (A to D), P.S. already written in highlighter
- Pigpen key, printed large
- Pencils, 20 take-home message cards with mini keys (ransom-notes PDF, last page)
- 2 blacklight flashlights
- Dark box (shoebox with a hand hole) if the room can't dim
- 4 CLUE 3 envelopes
- Backup sketch sheets

4 The Mummy Witness

Wrap and escape relay · Evidence envelope: **CLUE 4**

11 min | High energy | Arrive 1:05



SAY

"I am the witness. I saw everything. But I only speak to mummies. Wrap me."

Run it

1. Count off 1 to 5. **Round 1 (2 min):** all five wrap YOU head to toe, eyes and mouth free (jobs at right). Timer on. Then you "talk": "The witness box. Only a mummy may open it."
2. **Round 2, three 60-second heats:** two mummies at a time, each with a wrapper, the fifth detective on the stopwatch. At "time," mummies tear free and hobble to the box line. Three heats and everyone has been a mummy once.
3. The fastest mummy opens the box and takes **one** envelope. A second detective reads it aloud, a third writes it in the case file. It all means "the thief loves squishies."
4. "Detectives, bag the evidence." All paper in the trash bag before the bell.
5. At the bell: hand over the **CLUE 4** envelope. New rolls out.

Fixes

- Kid doesn't want to be wrapped: wrapper or timekeeper. Both count.
- Running out of paper: one roll per pair.
- Best-wrapped, fastest, and funniest mummy all get a shout-out.

Five detectives, five jobs

Count off 1 to 5 as they arrive. New count at every station, so the jobs shuffle.

1. **Round 1, all five wrap the witness:** 1 and 2 the legs, 3 and 4 the body and arms, 5 the head (eyes and mouth free).
2. **Heat A (60 sec):** 1 and 2 are mummies, 3 and 4 wrap them, 5 runs the stopwatch and judges.
3. **Heat B:** 3 and 4 are mummies, 1 and 2 wrap, 5 times it.
4. **Heat C:** 5 is the mummy, 1 and 2 wrap, 3 times it, 4 judges.
5. **The box:** the fastest mummy opens it and takes one envelope, a different detective reads it aloud, a third writes it in the case file.

What the statement means

Knew where the avocado one was, squeezed it, whispered "so satisfying," hugged the Jar like a puppy. One fact: the thief loves squishies.

Bin

- 14 rolls of the cheapest toilet paper
- Trash bags, stopwatch
- Witness box with 4 sealed statements (all the same)
- Tape for the start line, 10-foot hobble course
- 4 CLUE 4 envelopes
- Backup sketch sheets

FL

Floater / Photographer

Door, badges, restocks, photos, the hidden tags

Arrive 1:00 · Whole party



Before 1:30

- Crime-scene tape on the door frame (door stays usable). LED candle at each station.
- Cauldron and the Evidence Locker (under a cloth) by the Chief's desk.
- Spare badges and 5 case files on the door table.

Timeline

1. **1:30** Door: kids arrive wearing their squad badge (1 purple, 2 black, 3 teal, 4 orange); spare badges and the squad list for anyone who forgot. Each squad gets its numbered case file. Point each squad to the station with its number.
2. **1:38 to 2:28** Rotations: bathroom runs in pairs, restock stations (TP, vinegar, wipes), photos of each station (check the opt-out list first).
3. **Each bell:** dim the lights while the Detective plays the video; back up to "dim" when it ends.
4. **Rotation 3 (2:04):** hide the 20 highlighter-marked evidence tags around the room: under desks, inside books, under chairs. Nobody notices; they're busy.
5. **2:28** Deliberation: lights up. Snacks by squad if food is approved. Open the Wanted Poster table. Collect warrants into the cauldron. (The Detective handles the Chief's statement form.)
6. **2:40** Warrants read, Video 4 plays. Hand 3 blacklight flashlights to each squad. Stand by the lit hallway door during lights-out.
7. **2:48** Lights up. The Chief brings the Jar out. You run the trade: one tag, one squishy (candy layer first if there is one).
8. **2:55** Group photo with badges. Strike stations with the leads. Trash out. Tablecloths rolled and tossed.

Bin

- Spare badges (4 colors), 5 case files
- Spare TP, spare wipes, trash bags
- 20 evidence tags (highlighter-marked)
- 12 blacklight flashlights
- The EVIDENCE zip bag with one squishy (goes to the Detective before 1:30)
- Camera or phone, photo opt-out list
- Squad list from the Chief

The one thing that can't slip

The 20 tags must be hidden before 2:40. If rotation 3 gets away from you, hide them during rotation 4.

You are the only adult without a station. Everyone will ask you for things.

DET

The Detective's cue card

Opening, the live beat after Video 1, the finale lines



Room parent | Trench coat, clipboard

1:30 · THE OPENING (LIGHTS OFF, 90 SECONDS MAX)

"Detectives, we have a situation. Sometime yesterday afternoon, the Party Candy Jar, the one you have been staring at for a week, disappeared from that shelf. We don't know when. Yet. The door was locked. The window was shut. Somebody on this staff knows something. We have four suspects. Three of them have recorded statements, and you'll hear from them as the investigation unfolds. The fourth, the Custodian, declined to comment. Make of that what you will. We have four pieces of evidence, and exactly one hour before the trail goes cold. Your squad has a case file. Fill it in. Clear the innocent and you'll know who did it. Chief _____ has assured me she is not a suspect. Let's begin."

1:49 · RIGHT AFTER VIDEO 1 (THE PRINCIPAL)

Let the room react for five seconds. Then: "Did... did the Principal just say squishies?" Reach into the coat. Pull out the EVIDENCE zip bag with one squishy. "Recovered from under that shelf this morning. I assumed it was unrelated." Turn to the Chief. "Chief. What exactly was in that jar?" *The Chief, flustered: "Candy. ...Mostly. Candy-adjacent."* Back to the room: "Detectives. That jar was never candy. Open your case files. Cross out 'candy.' Write 'squishies.' This changes nothing about the evidence and everything about the motive. Rotate."

2:02 AND 2:15 · AFTER VIDEOS 2 AND 3

One line each, then the bell. "The Reading Specialist does not understand squishies. Noted. Rotate." / "Check their feet. Hm. Rotate."

2:28 · THE FIFTH STATEMENT

The first squad to say "everyone's crossed off" gets it said for the room: "Then your list is too short. Four clues: size 9, in the building at 2:15, blue sweater, loves squishies. Who else was in this building yesterday?" Let them guess. The Chief: "I am NOT a suspect." You: "Chief, you filled out a statement form like everyone else. For completeness. I have it right here." Pin it to the board next to the other four and read it aloud, including the crossed-out "Don't be ridiculous." "Detectives, check it against your clues. Then write your warrants."

2:40 · WARRANTS AND THE FINAL STATEMENT

Pull each warrant from the cauldron and read it aloud: "Squad 1 accuses... the Chief." The Chief protests: "This is outrageous. I'm the Chief." You: "There is one more statement. It was recorded under protest." Play Video 4. When it ends: "Detectives, you heard her. A very special light. In one minute the lights go out for three minutes. Flashlights to the squads. Every detective finds one tag. Then we open the Jar."